

UPSC PHILOSOPHY OPTIONAL

Indian Philosophy: Samkhya

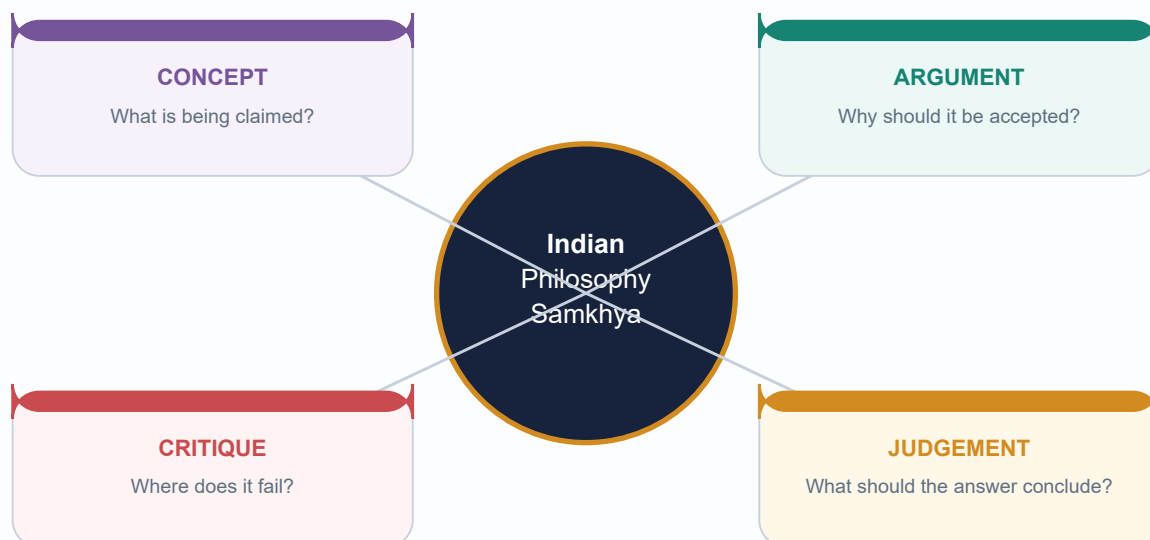
UPSC Philosophy Optional | Paper I | Indian Philosophy

Visual learning edition: central maps, argument flows, comparisons and PYQ frameworks

Syllabus: Prakriti; Purusa; Causation; Liberation.

Direct-source base: Chatterjee and Datta, Samkhya chapter (local PDF pp. 205-232); C. D. Sharma, Samkhya chapter (printed pp. 137-156); Radhakrishnan, Indian Philosophy Vol. II, Samkhya chapter.

Cross-checked with Paper I PYQs, 2022-2025.



Facts from official sources | Inferences clearly marked | No fabricated data

HIGH UPSC RELEVANCE

HIGH

Central Mind Map: Dualism and Evolution

Paper I
Philosophy

INTRO & ORIGIN

Samkhya explains experience through two independent principles: conscious but inactive Purusa and unconscious but active Prakriti. Bondage is their apparent identification; liberation is discriminative isolation.

The classical system is non-theistic and should not be described as materialism: it affirms irreducible consciousness as a plurality of Purusas.

SAMKHYA MASTER MAP

PURUSA WITNESSES; PRAKRITI EVOLVES

Purusa Pure consciousness, many, inactive, unchanging.	Prakriti One unmanifest material principle composed of three gunas.
Causation Satkaryavada: effect pre-exists in cause.	Evolution Prakriti unfolds through mahat, ahamkara, senses, subtle and gross elements.
Bondage Aviveka makes Purusa identify with Prakriti's states.	Kaivalya Viveka reveals complete distinction and ends experience for that Purusa.

WHOLE-SYSTEM CAUSAL FLOW



MEMORY HOOK

TWO REALS, THREE GUNAS, TWENTY-FIVE TATTVAS, ONE GOAL: discriminative isolation.

CONCEPT LINKS

Samkhya Concept	Linked Doctrine	Exam Value
Satkaryavada	Nyaya asatkaryavada	Pre-existing effect versus new beginning.
Parinamavada	Advaita vivartavada	Real transformation versus appearance.
Many Purusas	Advaita one Atman	Plural consciousness versus non-duality.
Prakriti	Yoga practice	Yoga adopts metaphysics but adds Isvara and discipline.

MAINS ANGLE

Samkhya's power lies in separating consciousness from the entire psycho-physical order, including intellect and ego.

STUDY LINK

Official syllabus item 16; always distinguish Purusa from buddhi, mind, and ego.

HIGH

Technical Terms: Prakriti, Gunas, and Purusa

Paper I
Philosophy

INTRO & ORIGIN

Prakriti is inferred as the common unmanifest cause of a correlated world; Purusa is inferred as the conscious witness for whom the aggregate exists.

KEY DATA

Term	Meaning	Argumentative Role
Prakriti / Pradhana	Uncaused, unconscious, unmanifest material cause.	Ground of all psycho-physical evolution.
Sattva	Light, manifestation, knowledge, pleasure.	Makes buddhi transparent to consciousness.
Rajas	Activity, stimulation, restlessness, pain.	Drives change and connects other gunas.
Tamas	Heaviness, obstruction, inertia, delusion.	Accounts for resistance and concealment.
Purusa	Pure witnessing consciousness.	Explains experience and liberation.
Buddhi / Mahat	First evolute; determinative intelligence.	Receives reflection of Purusa.
Ahamkara	I-maker or individuation principle.	Produces appropriation and differentiated faculties.
Aviveka	Failure to discriminate Purusa and Prakriti.	Cause of bondage.
Viveka-khyati	Discriminative insight.	Immediate means to kaivalya.

FIVE ROUTES TO PURUSA



STATIC THEORY

- **Plurality proof:** simultaneous differences in birth, death, capacities, and liberation imply many Purusas.
- **Prakriti proof:** limited and correlated effects point to a common unmanifest material ground.
- **Gunas are constituents:** they are not mere qualities added to Prakriti.
- **Teleology without consciousness in Prakriti:** evolution serves experience and liberation of Purusa.

MUST-KNOW FACTS

1. Purusa is conscious but not an agent; Prakriti is active but unconscious.
2. Mind, ego, and intellect belong to Prakriti, not Purusa.
3. Prakriti is one; Purusas are many.

MAINS ANGLE

The system avoids reducing consciousness to matter, but then faces the problem of relation between two independent principles.

STUDY LINK

Use the proof sequence for the 2022 Purusa PYQ.

HIGH

Satkaryavada and Evolution of Twenty-Five Tattvas

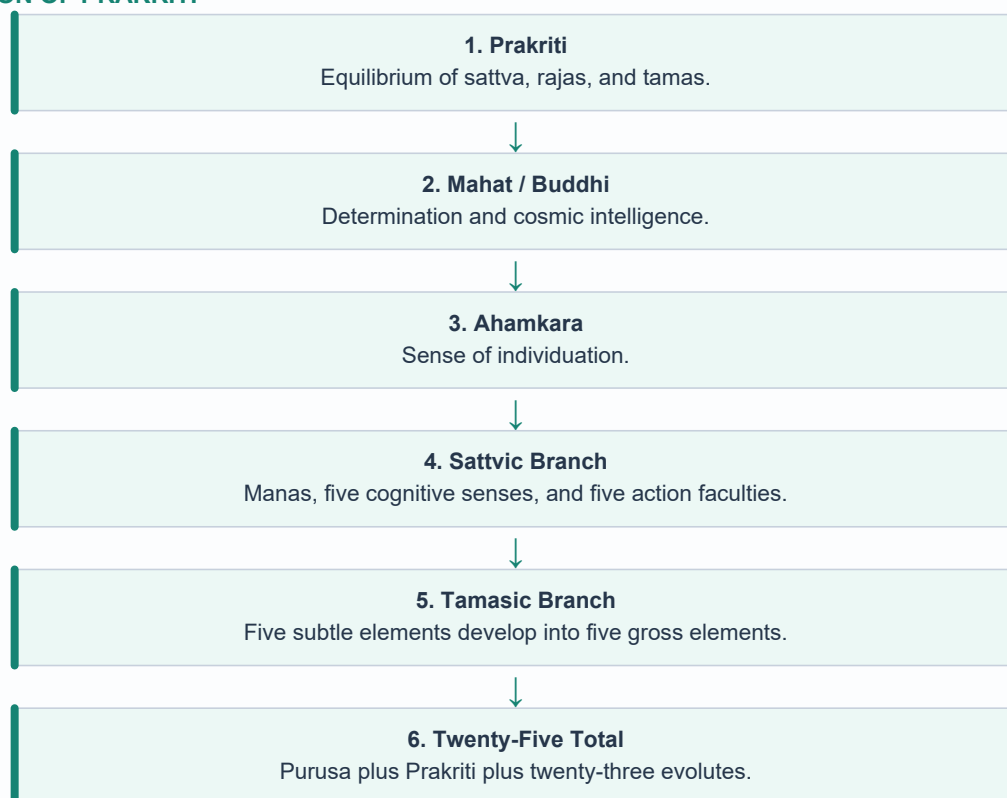
Paper I
Philosophy

INTRO & ORIGIN

Samkhya holds that production manifests what was already latent in the material cause. Evolution is therefore real transformation, not creation from nothing.

KEY DATA

Argument / Tattva	Meaning	Example or Function
Asadakaranat	What is wholly non-existent cannot be produced.	Nothing comes from nothing.
Upadana-grahanat	A specific material cause is required.	Curd requires milk.
Sarva-sambhava-abhavat	Not everything can arise from everything.	Specific effects reveal specific causes.
Saktasya sakya-karanat	A cause produces only what it has capacity to produce.	Capacity indicates latent effect.
Karana-bhavat	Effect is non-different in essence from its cause.	Manifest and unmanifest states.
Mahat / Buddhi	Cosmic intelligence and determinative faculty.	First evolve.
Ahamkara	Individuation into subject-object organization.	Produces faculties and subtle elements.
Eleven organs	Mind, five cognitive senses, five action faculties.	Sattvic line of evolution.
Five tanmatras	Subtle potentials of sensory qualities.	Tamasic line.
Five mahabhutas	Gross elements.	Material world.

EVOLUTION OF PRAKRITI

STATIC THEORY

- **Parinamavada:** cause genuinely transforms while preserving causal continuity.
- **Buddhi versus ahamkara:** buddhi determines; ahamkara appropriates as 'I' and differentiates faculties.
- **Mahat:** cosmic name for the first evolute; buddhi is its individual functional expression.
- **Rajas:** energizes both sattvic and tamasic products rather than forming a separate branch.

MEMORY HOOK

P-M-A-11-5-5: Prakriti -> Mahat -> Ahamkara -> eleven organs -> five subtle -> five gross.

MUST-KNOW FACTS

1. The twenty-five tattvas include Purusa and Prakriti.
2. The effect is latent, not numerically manifest, before production.
3. Evolution is real and reversible at dissolution.

MAINS ANGLE

Satkaryavada provides the logical foundation for Samkhya evolution: manifestation replaces creation ex nihilo.

STUDY LINK

Use all five arguments in causation answers; do not stop with the milk-curd example.

HIGH

Liberation and Strongest Criticism-Defence

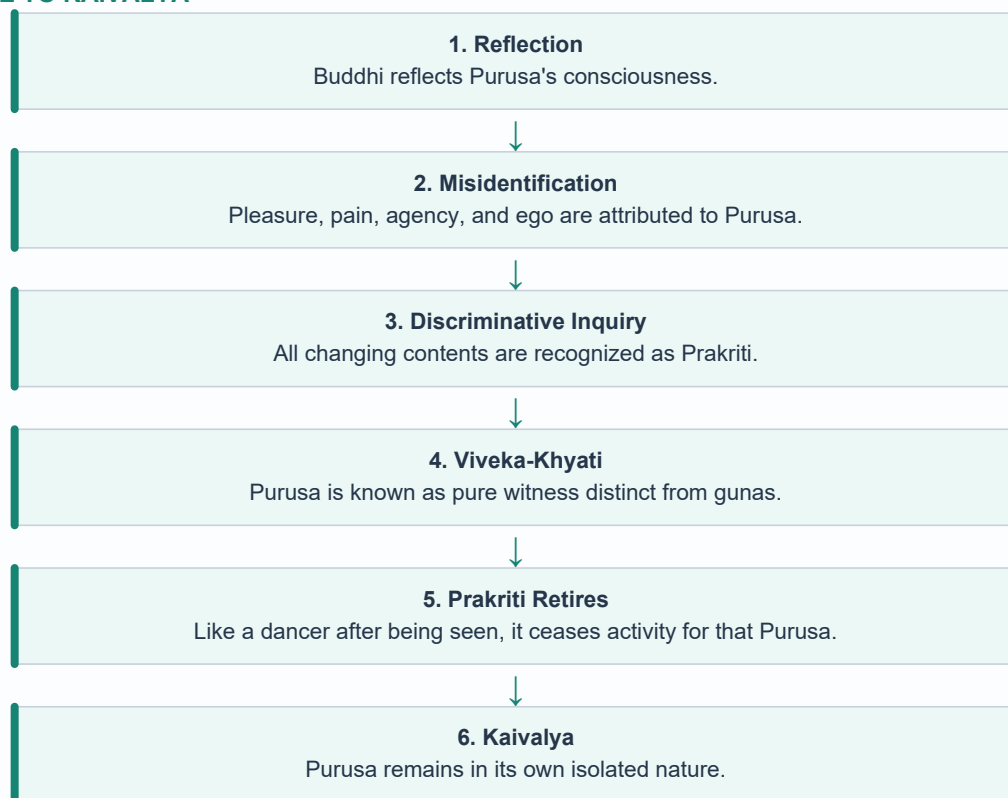
Paper I
Philosophy

INTRO & ORIGIN

Bondage does not modify Purusa; it is mistaken identification produced when consciousness reflected in buddhi appropriates Prakriti's states. Liberation is kaivalya, the isolation of the witness through discriminative knowledge.

KEY DATA

Issue	Criticism	Samkhya Defence / Qualification
Relation problem	Two wholly independent realities cannot enter relation.	Samyoga is proximity for experience, not a substantial fusion.
Inactive experiencer	An inactive Purusa cannot enjoy or seek release.	Experience belongs to buddhi but appears to Purusa through reflection.
Unconscious teleology	Prakriti cannot purposively act for another.	Its natural tendency functions like milk nourishing a calf.
Many Purusas	Pure consciousness has no differentiating qualities.	Plurality is inferred from distinct embodied careers and liberation.
No God	Order and moral fruition need an intelligent governor.	Prakriti and karma are sufficient; adding God creates further problems.
Kaivalya	If Purusa was always free, liberation seems redundant.	Liberation removes ignorance in buddhi, not bondage in Purusa itself.

BONDAGE TO KAIVALYA**STATIC THEORY**

- **Jivanmukti qualification:** residual bodily momentum may continue after insight.
- **Dancer analogy:** Prakriti displays herself for Purusa and retires once discriminated.
- **Chief Advaita criticism:** independent dualism cannot explain contact, and multiple Purusas lack internal differentiation.
- **Samkhya reply:** distinction is demanded by experience; non-duality risks collapsing witness into changing appearance.

COMPARISON TABLE

Issue	Samkhya	Contrast
Self	Many pure witnesses	Advaita: one non-dual consciousness
World	Real transformation of Prakriti	Advaita: appearance through maya
Method	Discriminative knowledge	Yoga: disciplined cessation plus Isvara
Liberation	Isolation	Ramanuja: communion with God

MAINS ANGLE

Samkhya brilliantly separates consciousness from mind, but the explanatory bridge between Purusa and Prakriti remains its central vulnerability.

STUDY LINK

Use Sankara's relation objection in 2023 and 2025 criticism questions.

HIGH

PYQ Routes and 10/15/20-Mark Answer Frameworks

Paper I
Philosophy

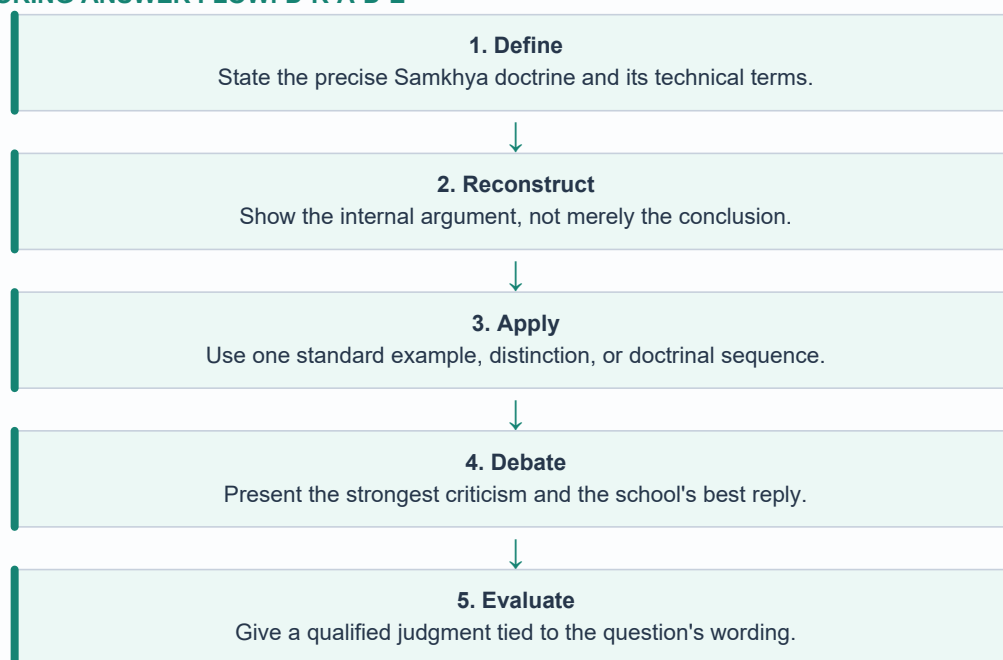
INTRO & ORIGIN

UPSC repeatedly tests a narrow doctrine through comparison, internal tension, criticism, or an applied example. The answer should reconstruct the school's reasoning before evaluating it.

KEY DATA

Year / Marks	Verified PYQ Route	Core Demand
2022 / 10	Proofs for existence of Purusa.	Five routes and plurality.
2023 / 10	Sankara's criticism of Purusa-Prakriti dualism.	Problem of relation between independent realities.
2023 / 15	Nyaya pragabhava against Samkhya causation.	Prior non-existence versus latent effect.
2024 / 20	Evolution of Prakriti; buddhi, mahat, and ahamkara.	Twenty-five tattvas and distinctions.
2025 / 20	Why Sankara treats Samkhya as chief opponent.	Shared Vedic ground, causation, dualism, unconscious Pradhana.

HIGH-SCORING ANSWER FLOW: D-R-A-D-E



STATIC THEORY

- **10 marks:** define Purusa or causation, state the numbered arguments, add one sharp objection.
- **15 marks:** explain the internal mechanism, compare Nyaya or Advaita, and defend the Samkhya distinction.
- **20 marks:** integrate satkaryavada, evolution, consciousness, relation problem, and kaivalya with a balanced final judgment.
- **Applied drill:** Use curd from milk to defend satkaryavada and then state the Nyaya objection.
- **Applied drill:** Reconstruct why intelligent but inactive Purusa and non-intelligent but active Prakriti require proximity, then test Sankara's relation objection.

MUST-KNOW FACTS

1. Write the Sanskrit technical term once, then explain it in plain language.
2. Separate exposition, criticism, defence, and final assessment.
3. Use comparison only where it clarifies the precise issue asked.
4. For statement questions, interpret the statement before presenting doctrine.

UPSC TRAPS

WRONG: Prakriti is ordinary physical matter.

CORRECT: It is the unmanifest source of mind and matter. Avoid reductive materialism.

WRONG: Purusa is an active agent.

CORRECT: It is inactive witness-consciousness. Central dualist distinction.

WRONG: Buddhi and Purusa are the same.

CORRECT: Buddhi is a subtle evolute reflecting Purusa. Essential for bondage.

WRONG: Satkaryavada means the visible effect already exists as visible.

CORRECT: The effect exists latently or potentially in the material cause. Clarifies production.

UPSC TRAPS AND CORRECTIONS

Common Trap	Correction	Answer Use
Prakriti is ordinary physical matter.	It is the unmanifest source of mind and matter.	Avoid reductive materialism.
Purusa is an active agent.	It is inactive witness-consciousness.	Central dualist distinction.
Buddhi and Purusa are the same.	Buddhi is a subtle evolute reflecting Purusa.	Essential for bondage.
Satkaryavada means the visible effect already exists as visible.	The effect exists latently or potentially in the material cause.	Clarifies production.

MAINS ANGLE

Samkhya is a profound non-reductive theory of consciousness and transformation, but its dualism succeeds only if proximity and reflection can explain interaction without compromising independence.

STUDY LINK

Revise the master map, doctrine table, criticism-defence grid, and PYQ routes together.